problem of how the Vedic people knew of the animal if it did not yet exist in the Sapta-Sindhu heartland. One possible explanation is that the word for lion (‘Singha’), at this stage of linguistic development, was also a generic word for big cats and was loosely used for both lions and tigers [9] . As we shall see, this dual use of the word is responsible for the naming of Singapore. However, Dr Divyabhanusinh Chavra, a leading expert on the Asiatic lion, still feels the Vedic description of a hunt suggests lions rather than tigers. Another explanation could be that while the lion was not common in the heartland, the Vedic people encountered it in lands to the west of the Indus (this would gel with the lion goblet found in Baluchistan). Yet again it must be admitted that we do not know enough about this period to be absolutely sure.

Whatever the exact circumstances of its entry, once the lion became a familiar animal in the subcontinent, it was quickly appropriated by Indian culture. As in the Middle East, it became the symbol of royal power and bravery. The word for ‘throne’ in Sanskrit and many Indian languages is ‘singhasana’ which literally means ‘seat of the lion’. Similarly, Durga, the Hindu goddess of strength and war, is usually depicted as standing on a lion while slaying a demon. The Mahabharata repeatedly invokes the image of a lion to convey strength and vigour. To this day, communities that are proud of their martial tradition, such as Rajputs and Sikhs, commonly use Singh (meaning lion) as their surname

Interestingly, the lion plays an important role in the *Mahavamsa*, a Pali epic, that is the foundation myth of the Sinhalese people of Sri Lanka. According to the Mahavamsa, the Sinhalese people are the descendants of Prince Vijaya and his followers who sailed down to Sri Lanka in the sixth century BC from what is now Orissa and West Bengal. The story tells us that Prince Vijaya was the son of a lion and a human princess, which is why the majority population of Sri Lanka call themselves the Sinhala—or the lion people—and the country’s national flag features a stylized lion holding a sword. Equally significant is the fact that the Tamil rebels of northern Sri Lanka chose to call themselves the ‘Tigers’. The ancient rivalry between the